

Park site one of McFarlin's problems as baseball coach

WHEN LARRY McFarlin accepted Andy Cohen's job as UTEP baseball coach two years ago, there was talk the Miners would instantly become competitive in the Western Athletic Conference.

Some thought Cohen's style of baseball was old fashioned. Besides, Andy was being paid peanuts by the athletic department for coaching the team. He did it more out of the goodness of his heart.

With Cohen's departure, UTEP was forced to upgrade the pay scale five times over what Cohen was making, but the salary still wasn't as much as a teacher-coach at MacArthur Intermediate makes.

Still, McFarlin accepted the challenge. Being a former Miner player, McFarlin was tired — like many El Pasoans — of watching WAC opponents batter UTEP to a pulp. He didn't mind the demotion in pay in order to move up from coaching ninth



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graders to a major college. Besides, the challenge was exciting.

McFarlin was hired too late by Athletic Director Jim Bowden to enjoy the summer recruiting season, so he inherited a returning infield and several players he thought could develop into fine athletes.

McFarlin initiated a full-season program which included lifting weights and playing several fall baseball games against local competition. By the time spring came around, McFarlin's optimism was bubbling.

"We want to win the WAC. I think if these players will come along, we'll be in the race," McFarlin said.

UTEP's new look, which included

blue trim on customary orange jerseys, took hold as the Miners began the 1979 season with an 8-2 mark that included three victories over powerful University of Oklahoma.

The Miners played .500 ball for the remaining 20 nonconference games but fell apart in WAC as so many past UTEP baseball teams have done.

McFARLIN THOUGHT that, with a year to recruit his own players, he would turn the program around in '80. He recruited a bullpen full of young talent and went the junior college route to acquire a first baseman, shortstop and center fielder.

The season started slowly as the Miners fell to 1-1 after a pair of four-game series against Lubbock Christian College and Nevada-Las Vegas. With the new season still young, the Miners learned that their campus field would be converted into a Business College.

Although the Miners mounted a 13-game winning streak, their concern grew about the future of UTEP baseball. Several players visited McFarlin's office seeking answers to their questions but all McFarlin could tell them was that he knew nothing about the possibility of a new field being built and he didn't know where they would be playing next year.

That question remains unanswered. There was a published report that the university and city were negotiating over land which would be partially converted into a new baseball diamond. No action, if any, is expected until late August and by then, there is doubt that a new park could be completed in time for the 1981 season.

"There are certain things that are in limbo right now. Nobody knows about the field or what's going to happen," McFarlin said. "It's not because of the field situation that I'm leaving. Even if they had a new field,

I wouldn't stay."

McFarlin's resignation Monday raises the question of whether the university plans to upgrade the program one step further by hiring someone with more experience than McFarlin had. From this vantage point, it appeared McFarlin did not have complete control of his players.

ON NUMEROUS occasions, his players defied his signals and did as they pleased. Maybe it was McFarlin's fiery temper — which had him ejected from three games this season — that was soaked up by some of his players.

Third baseman Mike Brooks verbally abused umpires to the point that McFarlin was finally forced to take disciplinary action against his only senior in the starting lineup.

Brooks and McFarlin became engaged in a shouting match during one

game late in the season and senior designated hitter Rick Hayes was suspended from the team after yelling at McFarlin for not playing him against New Mexico when his parents had traveled from Odessa to watch the game.

"You'll have flareups anytime. The kids are adults and have a mind of their own," McFarlin said of the incidents. "It's only natural."

Until McFarlin's replacement arrives, he'll go ahead with plans to send out letters and phone potential recruits. "I'll always have my eye out for recruits. We're going up to Wisconsin for three weeks and there are a couple of kids I'd like to recruit."

"If I go somewhere and see somebody I like, I'll go after them. I will continue to support the university and do whatever I can to help. There'll be one difference next year."

"I'll be in the stands."